stage. With Jimmy Carter in the White House, American foreign policy took a more cosmopolitan turn. Carter was attentive to the issue of human rights, and relations with China soon came under strain (even though, as a naval officer in the Second World War, he had 'fallen in love with the country and with its people'[25]). The new president was also upset with the rather cringing US attitude to China during the Nixon–Kissinger period. With India, after Mrs Gandhi's electoral defeat in 1977, there was the prospect of a new relationship.

In fact, however, Washington's relationship with Beijing strengthened rather than weakened. From 1972, leveraging on the new relationship with the Chinese, the US had brought the Soviets to the negotiating table on arms control and a wider political understanding that climaxed in the signing of the Helsinki Accords (1975). The détente with Moscow spectacularly collapsed four years later. In 1978, Afghanistan, far from the centre of Cold War geopolitics, was plunged into internal crisis due to the struggle between rival factions in the new revolutionary government. By December 1979, Moscow had sent in its forces to ensure the survival of its preferred communist faction. The US reaction to the intervention was to team first with Pakistan and then with China to recruit Islamist radicals to fight the Soviets in Afghanistan. Carter quickly saw that the US would have to release American high-technology and weaponry to China in order to persuade it to join the fight. Sensing the opportunity to hurt the USSR and enlist the US in its military and economic revival, Deng Xiaoping told visiting US Secretary of Defence Harold Brown: 'We must turn Afghanistan into a quagmire in which the Soviet Union is bogged down for a long time in guerrilla warfare.'[26] Beijing would go on to provide economic aid, but more importantly, arms and training to the insurgents.

The strategic partnership between the US and China deepened under Ronald Reagan in the 1980s. Reagan authorized an economic opening as well as the transfer of technology and weapons to China. He also granted Beijing Most Favoured Nation (MFN) status, made available credits and facilities by which China could import US technology, and persuaded Western allies to loosen Cold War rules that constrained high-tech exports